Technical Services Division was already ahead of Fleming. The Senate investigation into CIA covert action in 1975 solemnly recorded the 1967 CIA Inspector General's discovery that CIA toxicologists considered introducing thallium salts into Castro's shoes to make his beard fall out.[29] Either the idea came to naught, or *El Barbudo* wandered about with a false beard for the next fifty years.

By coincidence, DCI Dulles was about to present President Eisenhower with a 'Program of Covert Action against the Castro Regime,' which Ike had commissioned. The aim of the CIA plan was, 'to bring about the replacement of the Castro regime with one more devoted to the interests of the Cuban people and more acceptable to the U.S. in such a manner as to avoid any appearance of U.S. intervention.'[30] On 17 March 1960 Eisenhower approved the CIA plan to overthrow Castro, using a force of Cuban émigrés that the CIA would train and supply. Subsequently, President Miguel Ydigoras Fuentes agreed the training could be carried out on Guatemalan territory. Later, the Nicaraguan dictator, General Anastasio Somoza, allowed the attack on Cuba to be launched from Nicaraguan territory.

Initial agency planning envisaged infiltrating and supporting a guerrilla force in the mountains. In the autumn of 1961, however, the feasibility of a guerrilla campaign was reconsidered. A new approach involved an amphibious landing, supported by air power. Guerrilla warfare would be a fallback option should the invasion fail. The landing site, near the town of Trinidad on the south coast of Cuba, was three miles from the Escambray mountains, where anti-Castro insurgents were already operating. If things went wrong, the invaders could head for the hills and continue the fight. The CIA did not, of course, expect the operation to go wrong. They believed the amphibious landing would trigger a popular revolt.

Subverting (for) democracy

Shortly after it was founded in 1947, the CIA was tasked by President Harry Truman to engage in: